PLANORA

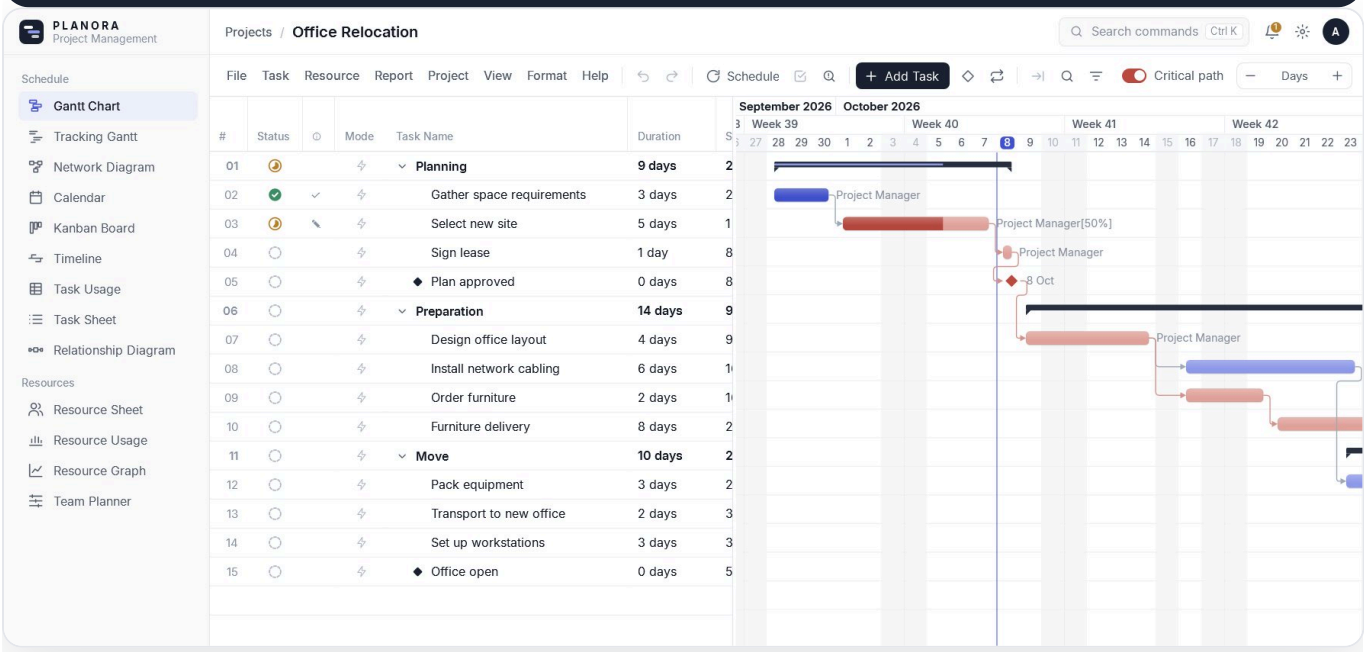
Planora vs Microsoft Project

A feature-by-feature comparison of Planora 1.0 with Microsoft Project Professional 2024 (desktop), including file compatibility, a scheduling accuracy test on real Microsoft Project files, and what Planora does not do.

Planora
Version 1.0.0

Compared with
Project Professional 2024

Edition
October 2026



188 / 188
task dates identical to Microsoft Project on three real .mpp plans

≈ 96%
of desktop Microsoft Project features (our estimate)

Free
vs US$680–1,130 one-time or US$30–55 per user per month

Developed by Adeeb

SUMMARY

The short answer

For planning, scheduling, tracking and reporting projects on a Windows PC, Planora does almost everything the desktop edition of Microsoft Project does, calculates the same dates, and opens Microsoft Project files — at no cost. Microsoft Project remains the choice when you need to **save .mpp files**, run **existing VBA macros**, or work inside Microsoft's **cloud and Office ecosystem** (Project Online, Project Server, SharePoint, Teams, Power BI).

At a glance

	Planora 1.0	Microsoft Project
Price	**Free**	Project Standard 2024 US$679.99, Professional 2024 US$1,129.99 (one PC, one user); or Planner and Project Plan 3 US$30 and Plan 5 US$55 per user per month
Platform	Windows 10 / 11, 64-bit	Windows desktop app; web app with subscription plans
Account or sign-in	None	Microsoft account or Microsoft 365 work account
Works offline	Always	Desktop: yes. Web: no
Installation	One Setup file, no administrator rights, nothing else required	Microsoft installer; licence activation
Native file format	.planora (opens .mpp; exchanges Microsoft Project XML)	.mpp
Interface	Sidebar of views, command bar with menus, command search (Ctrl+K)	Office ribbon
Collaboration	Share files (.planora, XML, PDF)	Project Online / Server, SharePoint, Teams
Automation	Built-in VBA-like macro language	VBA, COM automation, Office add-ins

How the comparison was made

Planora's columns describe features that exist in Planora 1.0 and were checked in its code and automated tests (305 tests). Microsoft Project's column describes the desktop **Project Professional 2024**; a few features (Team Planner, inactive tasks) are not in Project Standard. Prices are Microsoft's US list prices at the time of writing.

Yes Available Partial Available with limits (see notes) No Not available

FEATURE MATRIX

Scheduling and tasks

Feature	Planora	MS Project	Notes
Scheduling engine			
Critical path method, forward and backward pass	Yes	Yes	Same dates on real Microsoft Project files (see Accuracy).
Auto and manual scheduling	Yes	Yes	
Schedule from start or finish date	Yes	Yes	
Task types (fixed units, duration, work) and effort-driven	Yes	Yes	
Durations in minutes to months, elapsed, estimated	Yes	Yes	
Eight constraint types, honour-constraints option	Yes	Yes	
Deadlines	Yes	Yes	
Split tasks, split mode	Yes	Yes	
Recurring tasks	Yes	Yes	
Inactive tasks	Yes	Yes	Professional only in Microsoft Project.
Summary tasks, outline, WBS codes, collapse/expand	Yes	Yes	
Milestones	Yes	Yes	
Task Inspector (what drives a task)	Yes	Yes	
Task Path highlighting	Yes	Yes	
Dependencies			
FS, SS, FF, SF links with lag and lead	Yes	Yes	Including percentage and elapsed lag.
Link by dragging in the chart	Yes	Yes	
Autolink inserted or deleted tasks	Yes	Yes	
Links to tasks in other project files	Yes	Yes	
Calendars			
Project, task and resource calendars	Yes	Yes	
Exceptions with recurrence; work weeks	Yes	Yes	
Standard, 24 Hours and Night Shift base calendars	Yes	Yes	

FEATURE MATRIX

Resources, costs and tracking

Feature	Planora	MS Project	Notes
Resources			
Work, material and cost resources	Yes	Yes	
Max units, availability over time, resource calendars	Yes	Yes	
Standard, overtime, per-use rates; cost rate tables A–E	Yes	Yes	
Generic resources, booking type, budget resources	Yes	Yes	
Assignment units, work, delay, work contours	Yes	Yes	Eight contours plus period-by-period work.
Overallocation detection	Yes	Yes	Minute by minute up to month by month.
Resource leveling (order, range, slack, splits)	Yes	Yes	Not yet compared with Microsoft Project's leveling on the same files.
Shared resource pools	Yes	Yes	File-based pools.
Enterprise resource pool (Project Server)	No	Yes	Requires Project Online or Project Server.
Costs			
Resource, fixed and material costs; accrual	Yes	Yes	
Budgets	Yes	Yes	
Earned value (BCWS, BCWP, ACWP, SV, CV, EAC, BAC, VAC)	Yes	Yes	% Complete or Physical % Complete method.
Tracking			
11 baselines and 10 interim plans	Yes	Yes	
Status date, % complete, actual dates and durations	Yes	Yes	
Update Tasks, Update Project, Mark on Track	Yes	Yes	
Progress lines, Tracking Gantt, variance fields	Yes	Yes	
Timesheets and team status updates	No	Partial	Microsoft Project needs Project Online or Server for these.

FEATURE MATRIX

Views, customising and output

Feature	Planora	MS Project	Notes
Views			
Gantt Chart, Tracking Gantt, Task Sheet	Yes	Yes	
Network Diagram, Calendar, Timeline	Yes	Yes	
Task Usage, Resource Usage, Resource Graph	Yes	Yes	
Resource Sheet, Team Planner	Yes	Yes	Team Planner is Professional only in Microsoft Project.
Kanban / Task Board	Yes	Partial	In Microsoft Project, Task Boards come with the subscription desktop client.
Relationship Diagram	Yes	Yes	
Split views: Timeline, Details (Task / Resource Form)	Yes	Yes	
Command search across commands and tasks	Yes	Partial	Microsoft's “Tell me” searches commands only.
Schedule warnings panel	Yes	Partial	Planora collects late tasks, missed deadlines and overallocations in one list.
Customising			
Tables, filters (incl. interactive, AutoFilter, highlight), groups, sorting	Yes	Yes	
Custom fields: alias, lookup, formula, graphical indicators	Yes	Yes	Formulas cover the common functions (IIf, Switch, DateAdd, DateDiff, ProjDurConv…), not all of Microsoft's.
Outline codes	Yes	Yes	
Bar styles, text styles, timescale, gridlines	Yes	Yes	
Saved views, Organizer	Yes	Yes	
Themes	Yes	Yes	Planora: four accent colours.
Reports and output			
Built-in dashboards and reports	Yes	Yes	16 built-in reports.
Custom report designer	Partial	Yes	Text, figures, task tables, bar charts and resource tables; fewer chart types than Microsoft's.
Compare Projects	Yes	Yes	
Print with page setup, header, footer and legend	Yes	Yes	
Save as PDF; save view as image	Yes	Yes	

Visual Reports to Excel / Visio; Copy Picture to Office	No	Yes	
Productivity and safety			
Multi-level undo and redo	Yes	Yes	
Find, replace, fill down, spelling	Yes	Yes	
Templates	Yes	Yes	
Autosave and crash recovery	Yes	Partial	Microsoft Project autosaves; recovery relies on Windows/Office.

FEATURE MATRIX

Files, multiple projects, automation and cloud

Feature	Planora	MS Project	Notes
Microsoft Project files			
Open .mpp / .mpt	Yes	Yes	Planora reads them with MPXJ, including timephased work and splits.
Save .mpp	No	Yes	The format is closed; no free library can write it. Use Microsoft Project XML.
Microsoft Project XML, open and save	Yes	Yes	Planora writes XML in Microsoft's schema order; not yet tested by opening it in Microsoft Project.
Other formats			
Excel and CSV with an import map	Yes	Yes	
Primavera P6 XER and XML	Yes	No	Planora opens and exports both.
MPX	Yes	Partial	Current Microsoft Project opens MPX but no longer saves it.
Asta, Phoenix, GanttProject and others	Yes	No	Open only.
Multiple projects			
Subprojects and master projects	Yes	Yes	
Portfolio management, demand management	No	Partial	Plan 5 / Project Server only.
Automation			
Macros	Partial	Yes	Planora has its own VBA-like language; existing Microsoft Project VBA macros do not run.
COM automation, Office add-ins	No	Yes	
Cloud and Office integration			
Project Online, Project Server, web app	No	Yes	Subscription or server licences.
SharePoint task list sync, Teams, Power BI	No	Yes	

ACCURACY

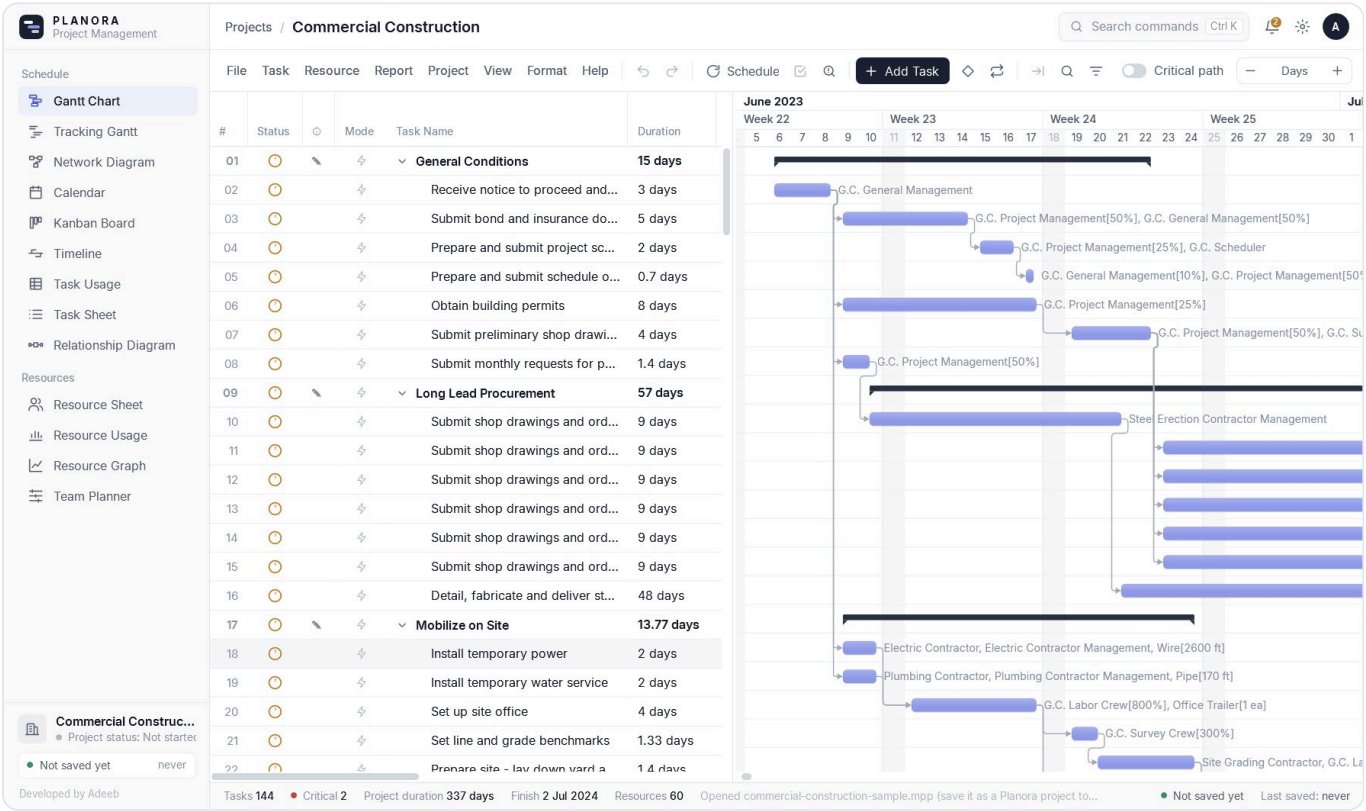
Scheduling accuracy on real Microsoft Project files

A scheduler is only as good as its dates. Planora was tested on three plans saved by Microsoft Project itself.

For each file, the dates Microsoft Project had stored were read from the .mpp; then Planora rescheduled the plan from scratch with its own engine and the two sets of dates were compared, task by task. This test runs automatically with every change to Planora.

File	Tasks	Start and finish dates identical
Advanced Analytics Microsoft Project Plan	34	34 / 34
Commercial construction sample	144	144 / 144
Product development sample	10	10 / 10
Total	**188**	**188 / 188**

“Identical” means within one minute: Microsoft Project stores seconds, Planora schedules in whole minutes. The plans include fixed-duration tasks, milestones with resources, interrupted (stop/resume) tasks, delayed assignments, cost and material resources and contoured work. One task shows a displayed duration of 181.8 hours where Microsoft Project shows 180 hours, with the same dates.



The commercial construction .mpp open in Planora (144 tasks, 60 resources).

CONCLUSION

What Planora does not do

- **Save .mpp files.** Planora opens them, but saves .planora and Microsoft Project XML. Microsoft Project opens the XML and can save it as .mpp.
- **Run Microsoft Project VBA macros**, COM automation or Office add-ins. Planora's own macro language covers common automation.
- **Connect to Microsoft's cloud**: Project Online, Project Server, SharePoint, Teams, Power BI, timesheets and portfolio management.
- **Visual Reports** to Excel or Visio, and Copy Picture to Office.
- **Run on Mac, Linux or the web.** Planora is a Windows desktop program.

Two areas have not yet been cross-checked against Microsoft Project: **resource leveling results** on the same files, and **opening Planora's XML in Microsoft Project**. Both are implemented and tested in Planora itself.

Which should you choose?

Choose Planora if you...	Choose Microsoft Project if you...
• plan and control projects on Windows PCs and want desktop Microsoft Project's scheduling at no cost • receive .mpp files and need to open, analyse and report them • exchange schedules with Primavera P6 users • work offline or without Microsoft 365 accounts • want a modern interface with command search	• must send editable .mpp files to clients or head office • depend on existing VBA macros or Office add-ins • use Project Online, Project Server, SharePoint or Teams for team updates and timesheets • need portfolio-level management across many projects

Sources and notes

Microsoft Project prices: Microsoft 365 Project plans and pricing page (microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/project/microsoft-project-enterprise-plans-and-pricing) and retailer listings for Project Standard and Professional 2024, US list prices in October 2026; prices vary by country and change over time. Planora facts: Planora 1.0.0 source code and its automated test suite. The feature coverage figure is an estimate by the Planora developer.

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